

MOTIVATIONAL INTERVIEWING

Implementation in Child Welfare

APRIL 2026

Heather Reed-Martinez & Katie Rollins



OVERVIEW OF TODAY'S SESSION



- What is MI?
- Family First & MI
- Shifting practice: workforce development
- Claiming & documentation
- Jurisdictional spotlight: NYC & Michigan



WHAT IS MOTIVATIONAL INTERVIEWING?

As described by the Motivational Interviewing Network of Trainers (MINT):

*"MI is a collaborative, goal-oriented style of communication with particular attention to the **language of change**. It is designed to strengthen personal motivation for and commitment to a specific goal by eliciting and exploring the **person's own reasons for change** within an atmosphere of acceptance and compassion."*

(Miller & Rollnick, 2013, p. 29)

WHAT IS MOTIVATIONAL INTERVIEWING?



Core MI Skills

- Open-ended questions
- Affirmations
- Reflections
- Summary statements



Guiding MI Spirit

Emphasizes a spirit of partnership, acceptance, compassion, and respect.



Key Tasks of MI

- Engaging
- Focusing
- Evoking
- Planning





Family First & MI

FAMILY FIRST & MOTIVATIONAL INTERVIEWING



*According to implementation science, **delivery of any EBP in new contexts calls for a fresh look at implementation methods**—calling on us to reexamine how we train and support practice, monitor fidelity, and integrate MI into the culture of organizations to ensure a fit with the child welfare and Family First context.*

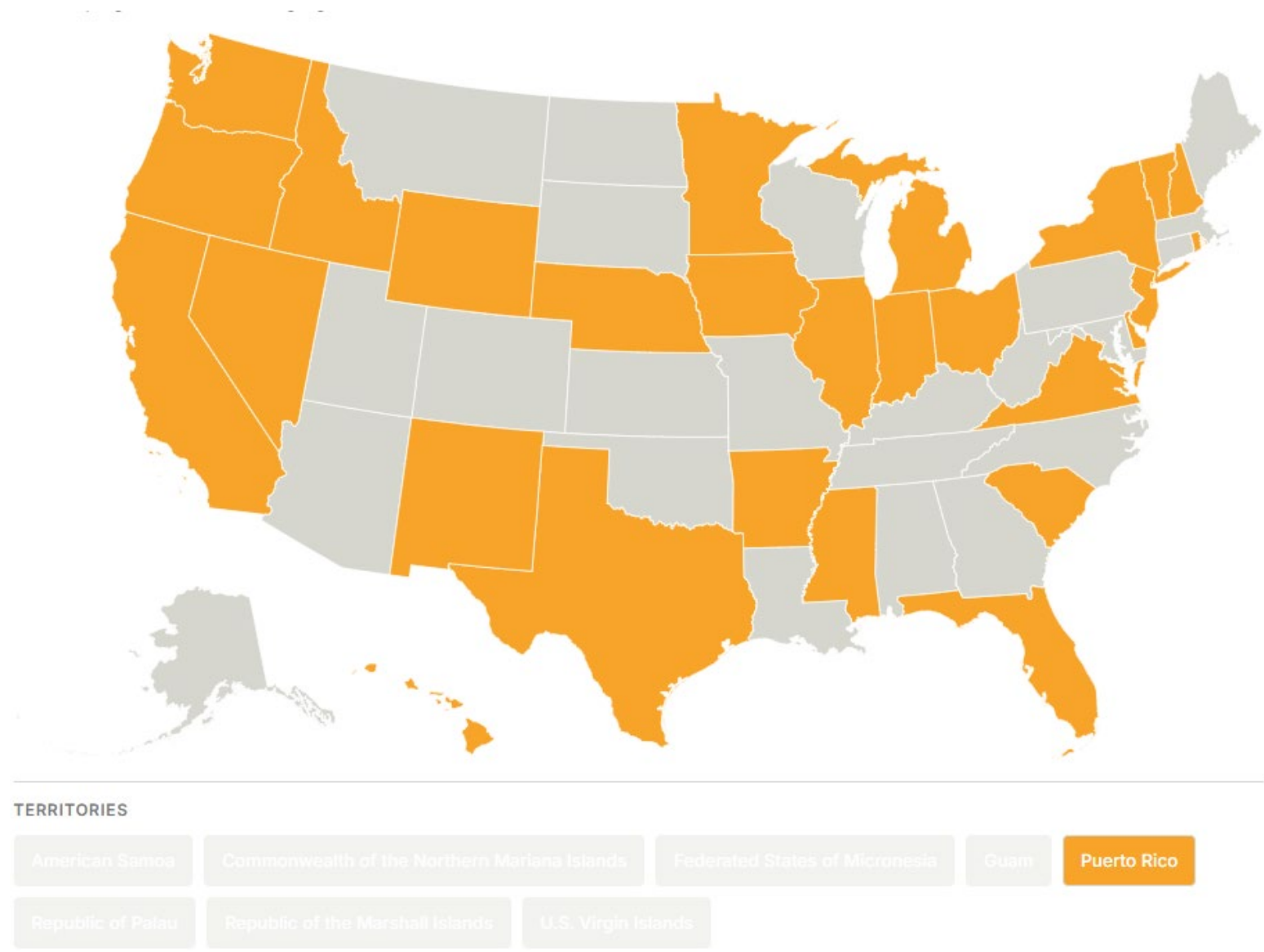
Listed as a **well-supported** EBP on the Title IV-E Clearinghouse.

Listed as a **substance abuse service** but used for mental health and parenting too.

Frequently **integrated with case management practice.**

29 states & territories are approved to claim for Motivational Interviewing

MI is the second most popular Family First EBP by this count





MI IMPLEMENTATION: KEY BENEFITS

Workforce

- Practical skills for effective & compassionate practice
- Reduced burnout and increased job satisfaction

Families

- Families' own motivations for change are elicited and elevated
- Families feel heard and respected
- Families open-up more: increased trust, sharing, engagement

System

- Part of a well-rounded prevention strategy: advances prevention and family engagement goals
- Broad claiming opportunity for child welfare, providers, & partners—including community pathways
- Allows for claiming EBPs at lower evidentiary levels under the 50% well-supported rule



MI IMPLEMENTATION: KEY CHALLENGES

With **no purveyor implementation guidance**, complicated implementation questions fall to jurisdictions.

Training & practice supports must be tailored to child welfare

Fidelity monitoring at scale that balances rigor & efficiency

Novel documentation & claiming methods

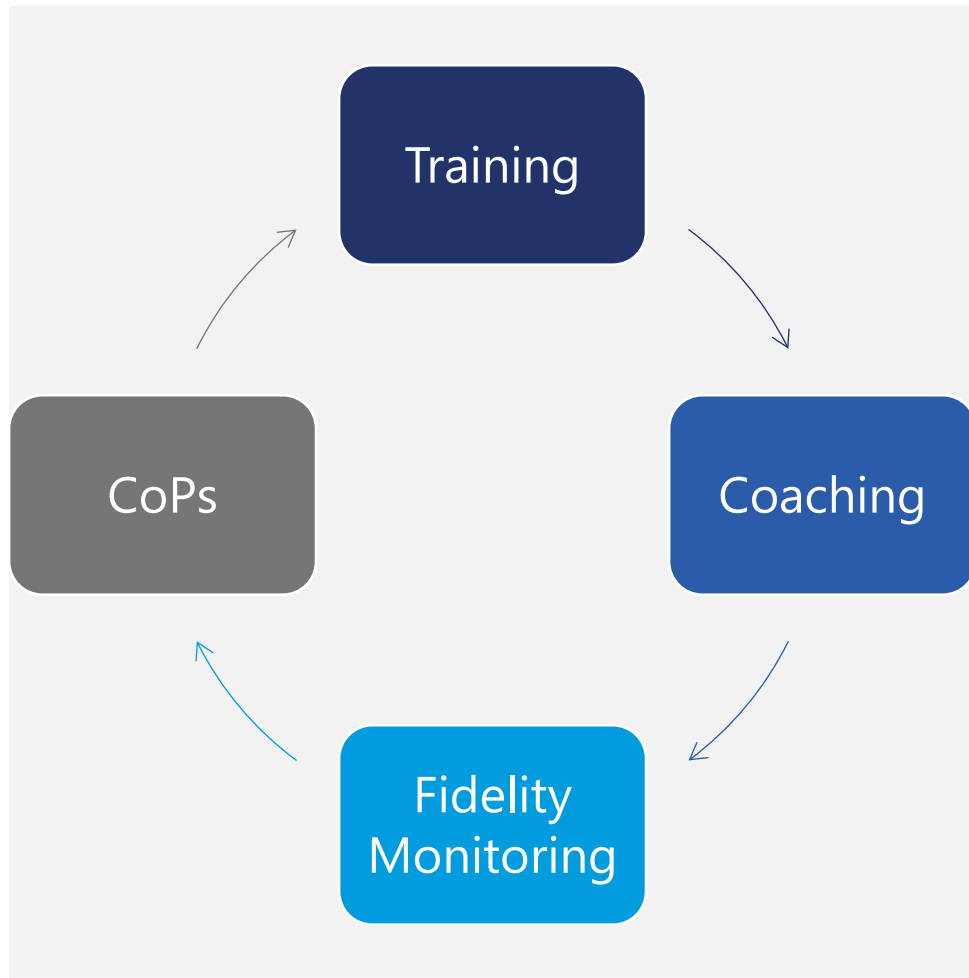
Multi-level communication & change management



Supporting a Shift in Practice

WHAT IS MI WORKFORCE DEVELOPMENT

MI implementation requires more than training alone. Sustainable practice changes requires alignment across all four components.



Training refers to the initial and ongoing training to develop MI skills

Coaching refers to the development of MI skills outside training, including in person and simulated practice and ongoing feedback from supervisors, peers, and trainers

Fidelity monitoring is the process of measuring the extent to which workers are carrying out a service or EBP with adherence to the intended approach

Communities of Practice (CoPs) are structured, ongoing learning communities where staff come together to share experiences, reflect on practice, and deepen MI skills over time

WHAT WE'VE LEARNED: MI MUST BE TAILORED TO CHILD WELFARE

What we've heard:

- ▶ Staff trained in standard MI feel the skills don't apply to their work
- ▶ Workers believe MI can only be used in some situations—not safety conversations
- ▶ MI Critics: "MI means being nice instead of protecting children"
- ▶ Result: low adoption, skepticism, and uneven use

Why this happens:

- ▶ Most MI training is designed for clinical, voluntary settings
- ▶ Scenarios and fidelity tools rarely reflect child welfare realities
- ▶ Authority, safety conversations, and mandated context are largely absent

**What staff say after
standard MI training (not
tailored to child welfare)**

*"This is great for prevention,
but I can't use it when I have
to address safety."*

*"I'm not a clinician or
therapist. How does this apply
to my job?"*

**These gaps signal a need to
address how MI is applied
in child welfare—not just
whether it is used.**

BRIDGING THE GAP: TAILORING MI FOR CHILD WELFARE

Apply MI with Purpose:

- MI is not a different model in child welfare or an adaptation. Its effective use requires intentional application within a context where staff must engage families while also addressing safety concerns, exercising authority, and guiding purposeful change conversations.

Effective use of MI in child welfare requires staff to:

- Be **clear and transparent** about concerns related to safety and well-being
- Use **authority purposefully** — not avoided, not overused
- Maintain **focus on behavior change** related to child safety
- Engage families in ways that support **reflection, ownership, and change**
This requires a shift from viewing MI as purely non-directive to understanding it as **both collaborative and purposeful** within a mandated system.

The Role of “Good Authority”

Effective MI in child welfare requires the transparent and purposeful use of authority. Staff operate in a mandated system and are responsible for ensuring child safety. This authority should not be minimized or avoided, but used in a way that is clear, fair, and aligned with the spirit of MI.

“Good authority” in this context means:

- Being transparent about concerns and expectations
- Clearly communicating risks, safety issues, and potential consequences
- Using authority to support, not replace, engagement and collaboration
- Neither overly directive nor conflict avoidant



BRIDGING THE GAP: **TAILORING MI FOR CHILD WELFARE**

MI in Child Welfare means: Direct and Engaging Communication

- A central principle of MI in child welfare is that staff are both clear and engaging in their communication.

Effective practice follows a consistent pattern:

- Staff clearly state concerns related to safety and well-being
- They then use MI skills to invite the parent or caregiver into the conversation
- The interaction remains focused on understanding perspectives and supporting change

This approach ensures that:

- Critical concerns are not avoided or delayed
- Families are actively engaged in responding to those concerns
- Conversations remain purposeful and focused on outcomes

KEY DECISIONS: WORKFORCE DEVELOPMENT

Every jurisdiction will need to make decisions across each of these areas. The following slides address the most critical considerations for training, coaching, fidelity, and CoPs.

Who Delivers

Training Format

Fidelity
Approach

Alignment

Building Buy-in

Sustainability

TRAINING

Core Considerations:

- **Capacity:** internal vs. external delivery
- **Format:** in-person, virtual, blended, asynchronous
- **Coverage:** new staff onboarding and existing workforce
- **Depth:** differentiated by role and desired proficiency level
- **Sustainability:** refresher, booster, and advanced training over time
- **Alignment** with the jurisdiction's existing practice model

Applying MI to Child Welfare: Training

Training should build on MI foundations AND include:

- Agenda setting and structuring conversations
- Purposeful use of authority
- Clear communication of concerns
- Consequences and consequence language
- CW-specific scenarios and role plays
- Linking behavior to child impact
- Integration with the jurisdiction's existing practice model

COACHING

Core considerations:

- **Who coaches:** supervisors, designated coaches, external consultants
- **Format:** individual, group, in-person, virtual
- **Frequency:** research supports 3–4 sessions over 6 months for skill sustainability
- **Structure:** observation of practice followed by specific, individualized feedback
- **Goal-setting** between sessions to support ongoing development
- **Standardized coaching tools** to ensure consistency across the jurisdiction

Applying MI to Child Welfare: Coaching

Coaching must reinforce MI foundations AND address:

- Observation and feedback should include CW-specific indicators — not just OARS and reflections ratio
- Address common drift patterns: softening concerns, staying in rapport without purpose, losing focus on safety
- Supervisors must be equipped to model MI in the CW context, not just observe it

FIDELITY

Most established fidelity tools were developed for voluntary, clinical settings and don't capture Child Welfare specific components.

Core considerations:

Fidelity monitoring can be approached in multiple ways. Jurisdictions should consider their capacity, infrastructure, and stage of implementation when designing their approach.

- **Instrument** — existing validated tool (e.g., MITI, BECCI) vs. adapted or purpose-built CW instrument; consider how well the tool reflects real child welfare interactions
- **Method** — simulation-based vs. in-vivo observation; simulation reduces recording barriers while in-vivo captures real practice but raises feasibility and confidentiality considerations
- **Who codes** — internal supervisors, designated coders, external raters, or AI-assisted tools; each has tradeoffs for cost, consistency, and sustainability
- **Frequency** — right-size the system; overly intensive monitoring often becomes unsustainable and can crowd out the coaching and supervision that actually drives practice change
- **Use of results** — fidelity data should feed directly into coaching and supervision, not function as a standalone compliance measure

Applying MI in Child Welfare: Fidelity

When selecting or adapting a tool, ask:

- Does it capture clarity of concerns, purposeful focus, and appropriate use of authority — not just OARS and reflections ratio?
- Does it reflect what MI actually looks like in a safety-focused, mandated conversation?
- Is it being used as a learning and coaching tool, or only as a scoring mechanism?

Rigor matters — but so does fit. Fidelity approaches should preserve core MI principles while aligning with child welfare practice realities.

COMMUNITIES OF PRACTICE (COP)

Core considerations:

- **Structure** — CoPs work best when they have a consistent format, a designated facilitator, and a clear focus; ad hoc peer conversations are valuable but don't replace structured learning communities
- **Frequency** — regular, scheduled meetings sustain momentum; monthly or bi-monthly tends to be manageable for most jurisdictions
- **Facilitation** — who leads matters; a skilled facilitator keeps discussion grounded in practice, not just general conversation
- **Scope** — CoPs can be organized by role (supervisors, frontline workers), by program area, or across the jurisdiction depending on size and structure

Applying MI in Child Welfare: CoPs

Why CoPs matter for MI specifically:

MI is a skill that develops through ongoing practice and reflection — not something you learn once and maintain automatically. CoPs give staff a structured space to bring real questions, share what's working, and keep learning from each other between coaching sessions.

In child welfare specifically: CoPs are a valuable space to work through the practice tensions unique to this context — addressing safety directly, maintaining engagement with resistant parents, using authority in a way that aligns with MI. These benefit from peer reflection, not just individual coaching.

MAKING IT STICK: ALIGNMENT, BUY-IN, AND SUSTAINABILITY

Alignment

- What is trained must be what is coached and what is measured
- MI should reinforce — not compete with — the jurisdiction's existing practice model
- Supervisors are the critical link; their proficiency and buy-in directly shape whether MI is reinforced in day-to-day practice

Building Buy-In

- Start early — engage leadership, supervisors, and frontline staff before and during implementation, not after
- Address the "nice vs. protective" misconception directly in training and communication
- Help staff see MI as strengthening the work they already do, not replacing it
- Consistent messaging across all levels reduces resistance and misinformation

Sustainability

- Plan for new staff from day one — onboarding should introduce MI immediately and connect it to the practice model
- Communities of practice and peer learning structures maintain momentum beyond initial training
- Right-size fidelity and coaching so they can be maintained without heavy external support
- Plan for leadership transitions — implementation should not depend on a single champion or cohort

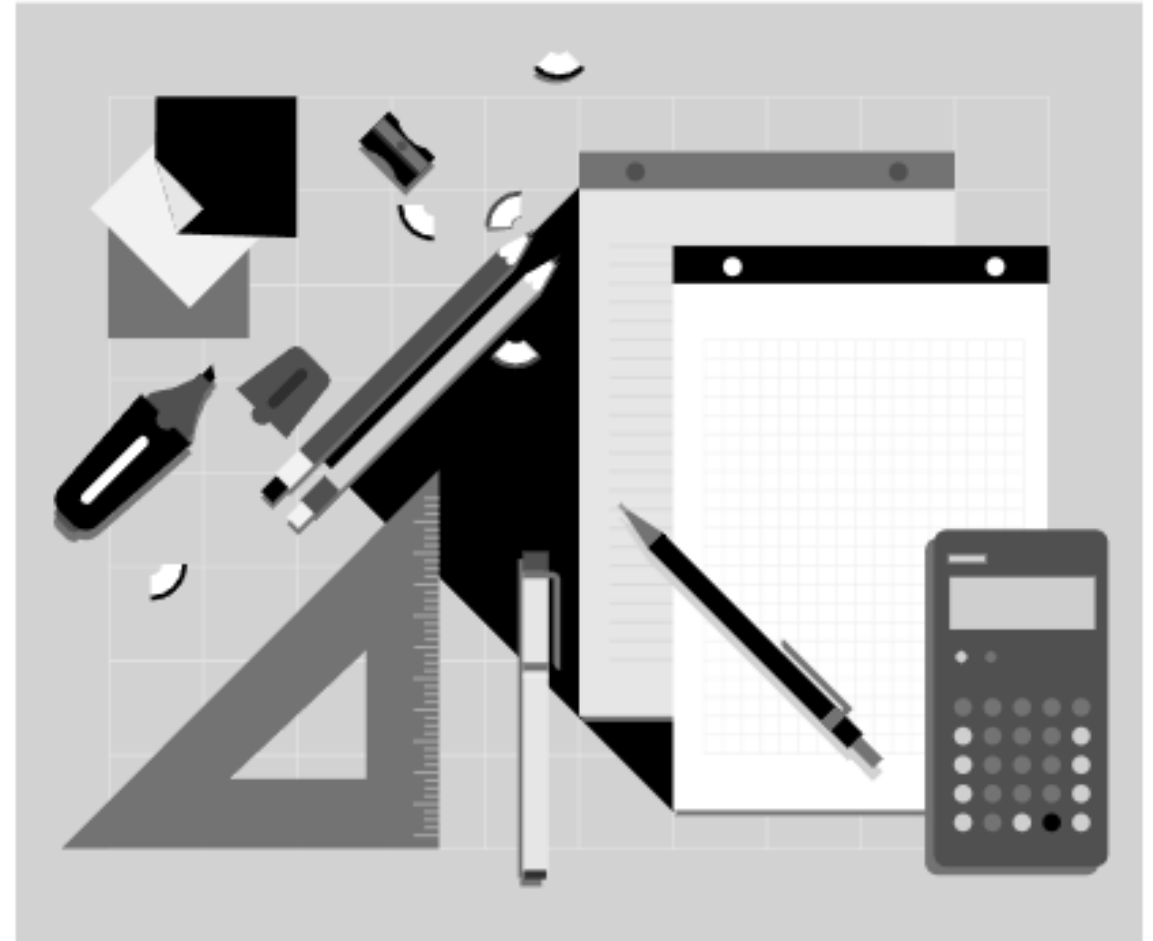


A word on

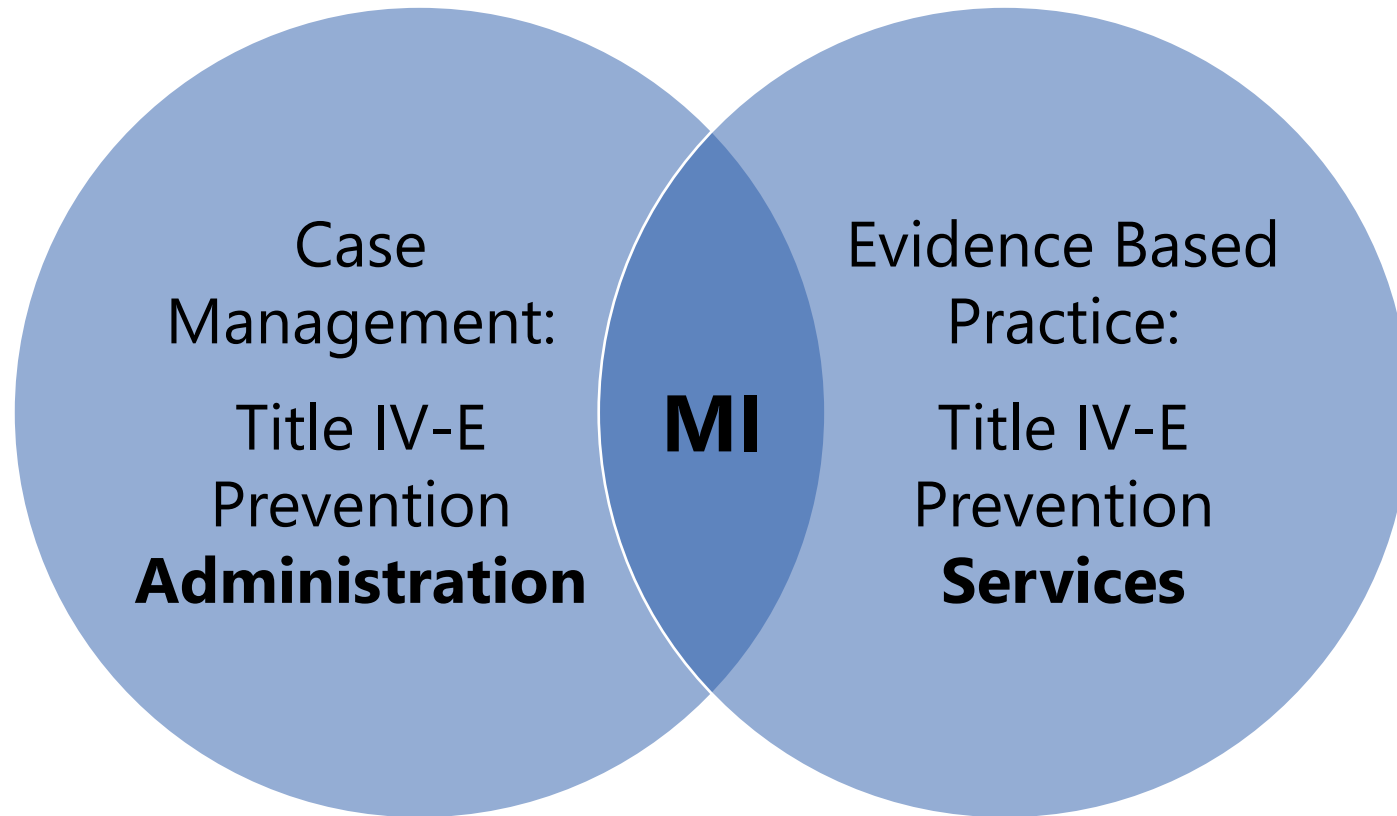
Documentation & Claiming

MI CLAIMING CONSIDERATIONS

- Who will provide MI to be claimed?
- How will we confirm that the individual delivering MI is qualified?
- What type of claim will we submit (Administrative Costs or Services)?
- If claiming as a service, how will we define a unit of the service and calculate costs?
- How will we document as required?



Motivational
Interviewing,
when delivered by
a case manager,
is both an EBP
service and an
allowable
administrative
activity.





Jurisdictional Panel

Motivational Interviewing

MDHHS implementation of MI for Title IV-E Prevention

Alexandria Fedewa & Deanne Lux



Michigan's Implementation Timeline

Nearly 6,000 people have been trained so far!

- October 2021 through December 2023
 - Phased approach to train all 83 counties
 - Child Welfare case managers, MQAAs, Supervisors, and Program Managers
- 2024 and beyond!
 - Ongoing Child Welfare
 - Family Preservation
 - Select Prevention Providers



MI Training



Required Trainings

- Introduction to Motivational Interviewing (*required for everyone*)
- FFPSA Elements in MiSACWIS (*required for everyone*)
- Small Group Coaching for Motivational Interviewing (*required for Supervisors, Program Managers, MQAAs*)
- MiTEAM Fidelity Training inc. Motivational Interviewing (*required for Supervisors, Program Managers, MQAAs*)
- Fidelity Inter Rater Reliability (*required for Supervisors, Program Managers, MQAAs*) (coming soon!)
- Program Manager Training 4: Facilitating Motivational Interviewing Learning Groups (*required for Program Managers*)

Optional Extra Supports

- Recorded Refresher content (*coming soon!*)
- Motivational Interviewing Refresher: Strengthening Skills for Case Managers and Supervisors
- Program Manager Training 5: Motivational Interviewing Lab: Collaborative Solutions

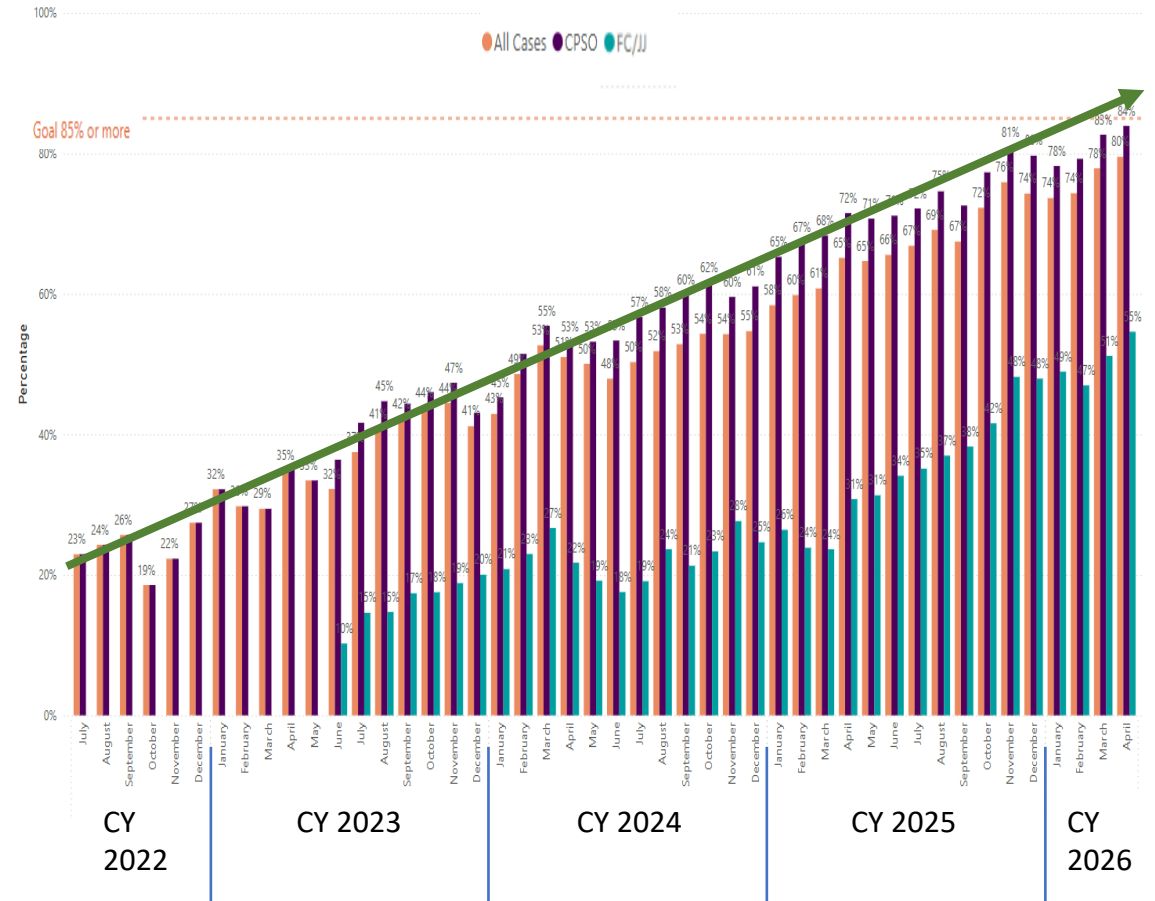
MI Data Entry Rates Growth

Social Work Contacts and IV-E
Prevention Plans entered for eligible
populations

Graph shows increase in data entry from
beginning through today.

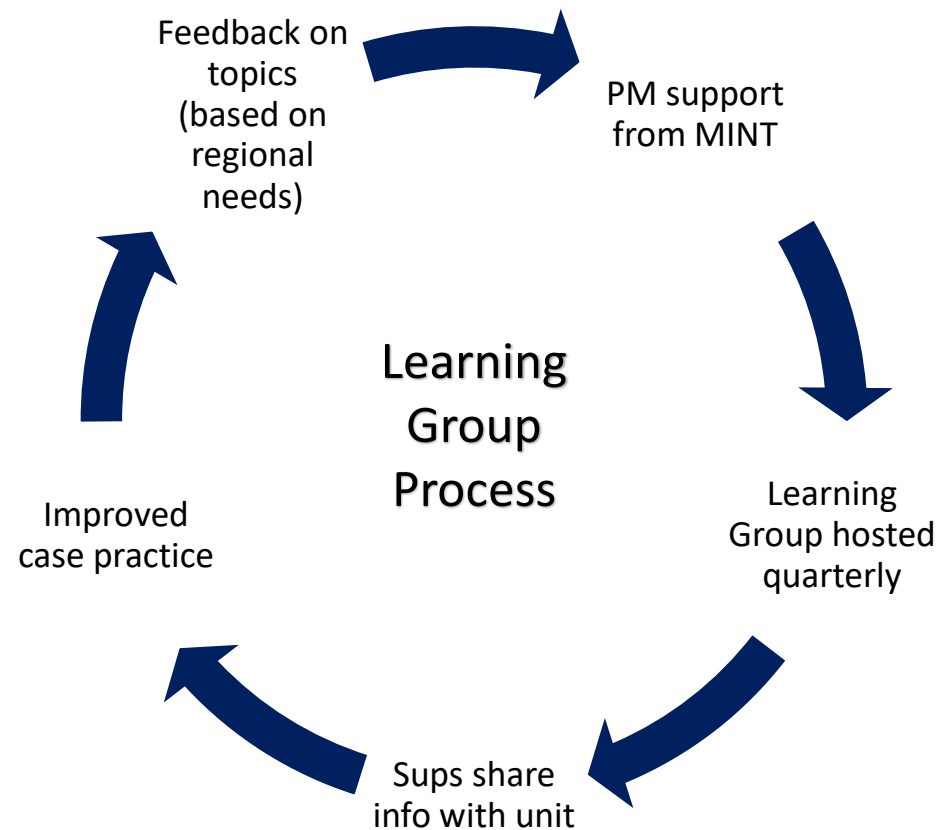
Ongoing CQI efforts to support data entry
and understanding the why behind data
entry.

Regional Prevention Analysts support
counties.

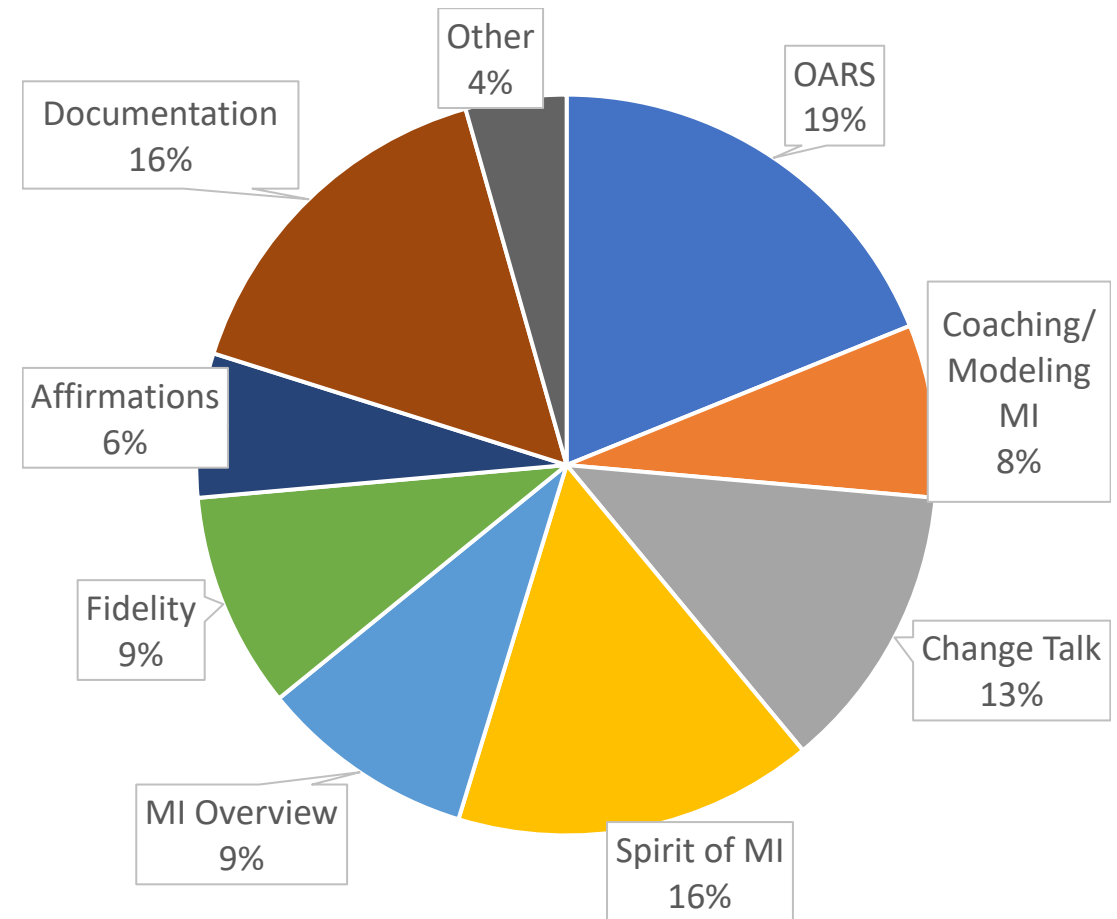


Learning Groups

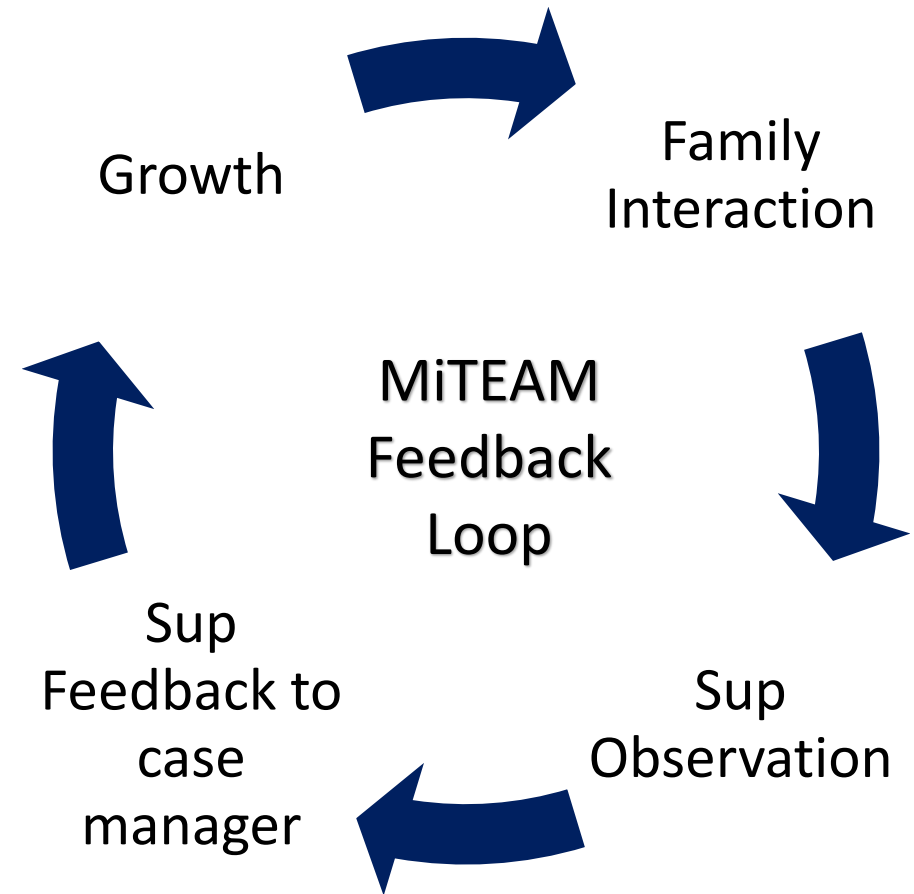
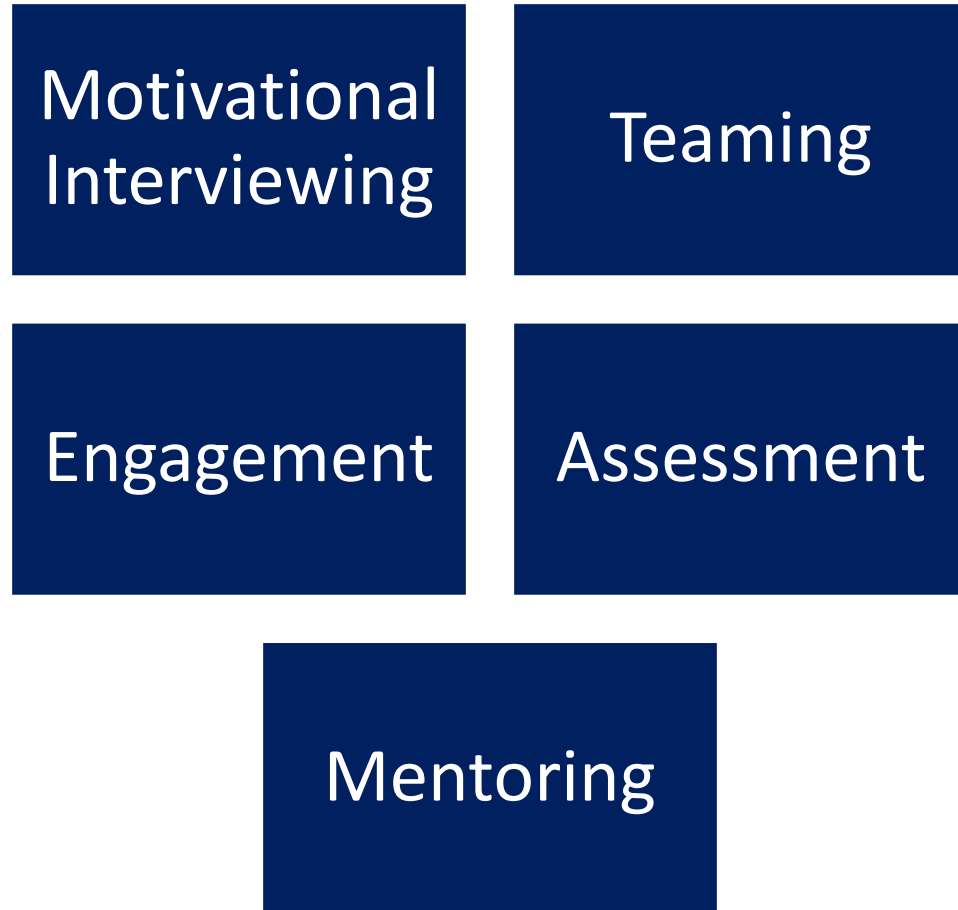
Intentional part of MI process



Topic Quantities



Motivational Interviewing in MiTEAM Fidelity



MI Populations

With IV-E Funding

- Child Welfare
Case Managers, Supervisors, Program Managers
- Maltreatment in Care
Investigators, Supervisors, Program Managers
- Centralized Intake department
- Substance Use Disorder Family Support Program-with Motivational Interviewing
- Post Adoption Resource Centers

Without IV-E currently

- Family Preservation Providers
- Additional Prevention Providers

Next Steps

- Ongoing reinforcement of the mindset around engagement
 - How do we help staff understand the small concepts of engagement that can use MI and in all interactions
- Continue discussions around expanding MI Populations and claiming opportunities
- Ongoing Feedback Loops and reinforcement of the intent

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NYC ACS Rollout of MI Connect to Support FFPSA Implementation

INTRODUCTION

CHERYL BEAMON

Associate Commissioner

ACS Office Training & Workforce Development

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KATE CHARTAN

Chief Operating Officer

ACS Office Training & Workforce Development

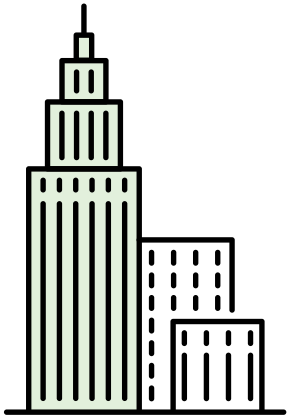
kate.chartan@acs.nyc.gov





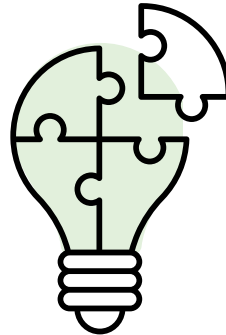
NYC CHILD WELFARE SYSTEM

Our system is county administered with state oversight. We contract with partner agencies to provide foster care and prevention services.



41

**PREVENTION
AGENCIES**



14

**PREVENTION EVIDENCE-
BASED/EVIDENCE-
INFORMED MODELS**



33,033

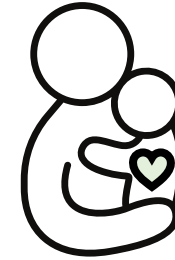
**CHILDREN SERVED BY
PREVENTION
PROGRAMS IN 2025**

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OUR MI APPROACH

H Since 2016, MI training has been a foundational framework for NYC child welfare. It has been a required training for prevention since 2018, and is now a required training across the child welfare continuum.

MI values the voice of
families



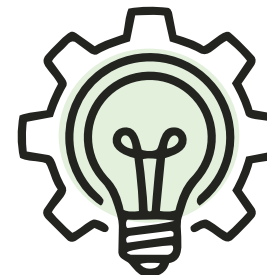
Families are the experts
in their own lives

Coaching values the
voice of supervisors &
direct service staff



Supervisors & direct
service staff are the
experts in their work

MI Connect continues
the learning journey



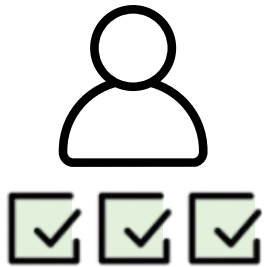
Supporting staff in
applying MI to strengthen
family engagement

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MI CONNECT

LEARNING JOURNEYS

SUPERVISOR LEARNING JOURNEY



PREREQUISITES

- Foundations of Motivational Interviewing: Communicating to Build Partnerships
- Foundations of Motivational Interviewing: Practicum
- Building Coaching Competency



USING COACHING TO ADVANCE MI

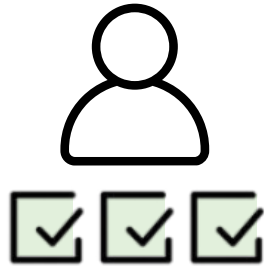
Equips supervisors with the skills to coach their staff to use MI.



COACHING

Provides practice opportunities and guidance as supervisors coach staff around integrating MI in their practice.

DIRECT SERVICE STAFF LEARNING JOURNEY



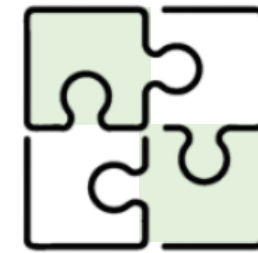
PREREQUISITES

- Foundations of Motivational Interviewing: Communicating to Build Partnerships
- Foundations of Motivational Interviewing: Practicum



MI SKILLS CHECK

Offers immediate, actionable feedback to support direct service staff in strengthening their MI skills. Participants will have two weeks to complete their MI Skills Check.



MI GROUP PRACTICE

Provides opportunities for direct service staff to refine techniques, build confidence, and strengthen overall proficiency in MI:

- Identifying and Responding to Ambivalence, Change Talk, and Sustain Talk
- Reflections to Engage, Partner, and Move Toward Change
- Open-Ended Questions and Open Prompts
- MI-Consistent Approaches

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MOTIVATIONAL INTERVIEWING (MI) SKILLS CHECK

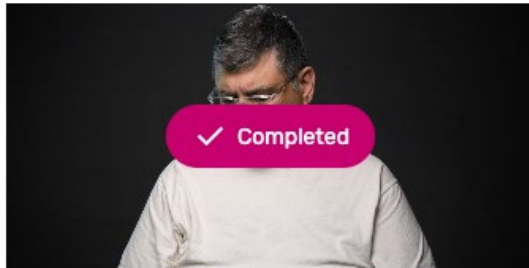
Watch

Learn

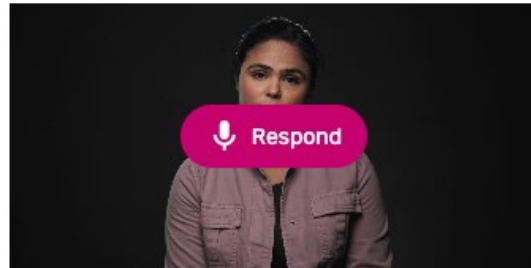
Practice

So, that's it! Now you have your first skill in the Toolbox: Listening Statements. Now let's try it out with a few examples.

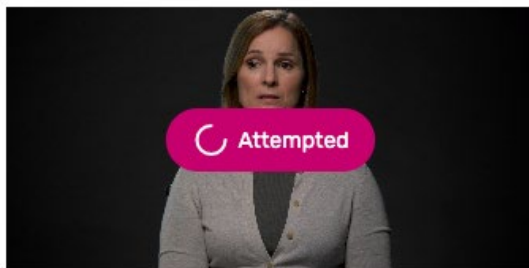
Miguel [about](#)



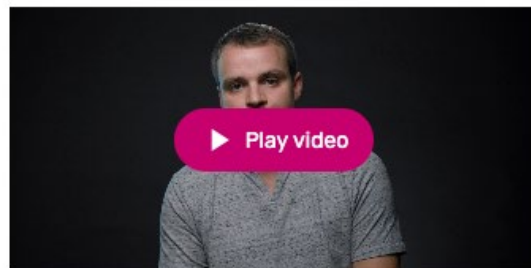
Gabriella [about](#)



Jeanette [about](#)



Ryan [about](#)



You're wondering if you're sabotaging yourself because it seems like it should be so simple **LISTENING STATEMENT**

Great example of a listening statement (reflection). Remember the goal is to help the client feel that you are hearing them, and potentially to pick up on nuances of what they are saying that they might not even notice themselves! There are tons of things you could reflect in any client statement, maybe try a few different ones to see how they land. **You completed this client prompt, which means you responded on target at least once to this client.**

Do you think that that action was helpful? And do you think that that was the right thing to do? **CLOSED QUESTION**

In this response, it looks like you were asking a question rather than making a listening statement (reflection). The difference is tricky – often it is because the tone at the end rises to make a question mark instead of staying even to make a statement. With a little practice, this will improve, but it will feel awkward at first. Also, remember to focus on making a direct observation or summary of what the client said rather than asking them for more information. Don't worry, if you make a nice listening statement, the client will keep going, even without questions. **You've attempted this client prompt, which means you have not yet responded on target.**



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AI MI CONNECT GOVERNANCE COMMITTEE

Based on the ACS AI Review Committee recommendation, we are establishing an AI MI Connect Governance Committee and a formal bias review process to ensure the responsible, transparent, and equitable use of AI in evaluating Motivational Interviewing (MI) skills. The bias review evaluates two key areas:

- **Accuracy:** How closely the AI's scoring matches ratings from trained human reviewers.
- **Fairness:** Whether AI scores differ in systematic ways across different learner demographic or background groups.

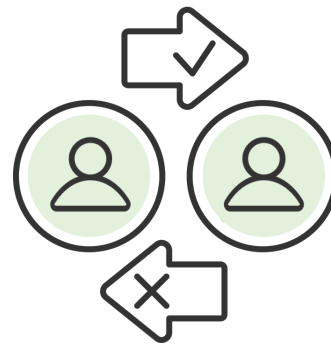
MI CONNECT BIAS REVIEW PROCESS

ACS coders are trained in the Motivational Interviewing Treatment Integrity Coding Manual 4.2.1 to accurately identify and classify core MI skills—reflections, affirmations, information-giving, collaboration, and open questions—using consistent definitions and coding criteria.



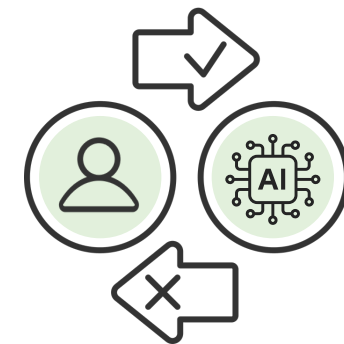
SAMPLING

Stratified random sampling of participant demographics ensures fair comparisons across groups, using a 20% proportional sample to support rigorous, bias-sensitive analysis.



HUMAN INTER-RATER RELIABILITY

Independent blind coding is conducted by raters, with discrepancies resolved through structured adjudication. A Cohen's kappa score below 0.60 signals the need for additional training and calibration before proceeding.



AI INTER-RATER RELIABILITY

Agreement between AI and human consensus is assessed using Cohen's kappa to evaluate consistency in coding decisions across participants' demographics, with values above 0.61 indicating substantial agreement and values below 0.60 triggering review and recalibration.



CONTINUOUS QUALITY IMPROVEMENT

We will:

- Use the data from the Bias Review to make changes to ensure the tool is effective for and reflective of our workforce.
- Develop customized NYC-specific vignettes based on trends.
- Engage in the Bias Review process biannually to ensure ongoing improvement.



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MI CONNECT

COACHING



COACHING TO SUPPORT THE USE OF MI

We hold an initial onsite meeting with each agency that includes Program Leaders and Supervisors to ensure that coaching is:

- Customized to meet each agency's specific needs.
- Aligned with the EBM(s) each agency is using.

There will be one Coach per agency who will offer sessions onsite and virtually. Coaching opportunities will be 1:1 or in groups.



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MI CONNECT

INITIAL IMPLEMENTATION

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WAVE

ROLLOUT

- > 40 Agencies*
- > 870 Direct Service Staff
- > 227 Supervisors

* Some programs are not included in MI Connect.

WAVE

1

JAN 2026

Three Agencies

- 65 Direct Service Staff
- 17 Supervisors

WAVE

2

JAN 2026

Eleven Agencies

- 168 Direct Service Staff
- 43 Supervisors

WAVE

3

FEB 2026

Seven agencies

- 170 Direct Service Staff
- 47 Supervisors

WAVE

4

MAR 2026

Eight Agencies

- 197 Direct Service Staff
- 44 Supervisors

WAVE

5

APR 2026

Three Agencies

- 124 Direct Service Staff
- 29 Supervisors

WAVE

6

MAY 2026

Eight Agencies

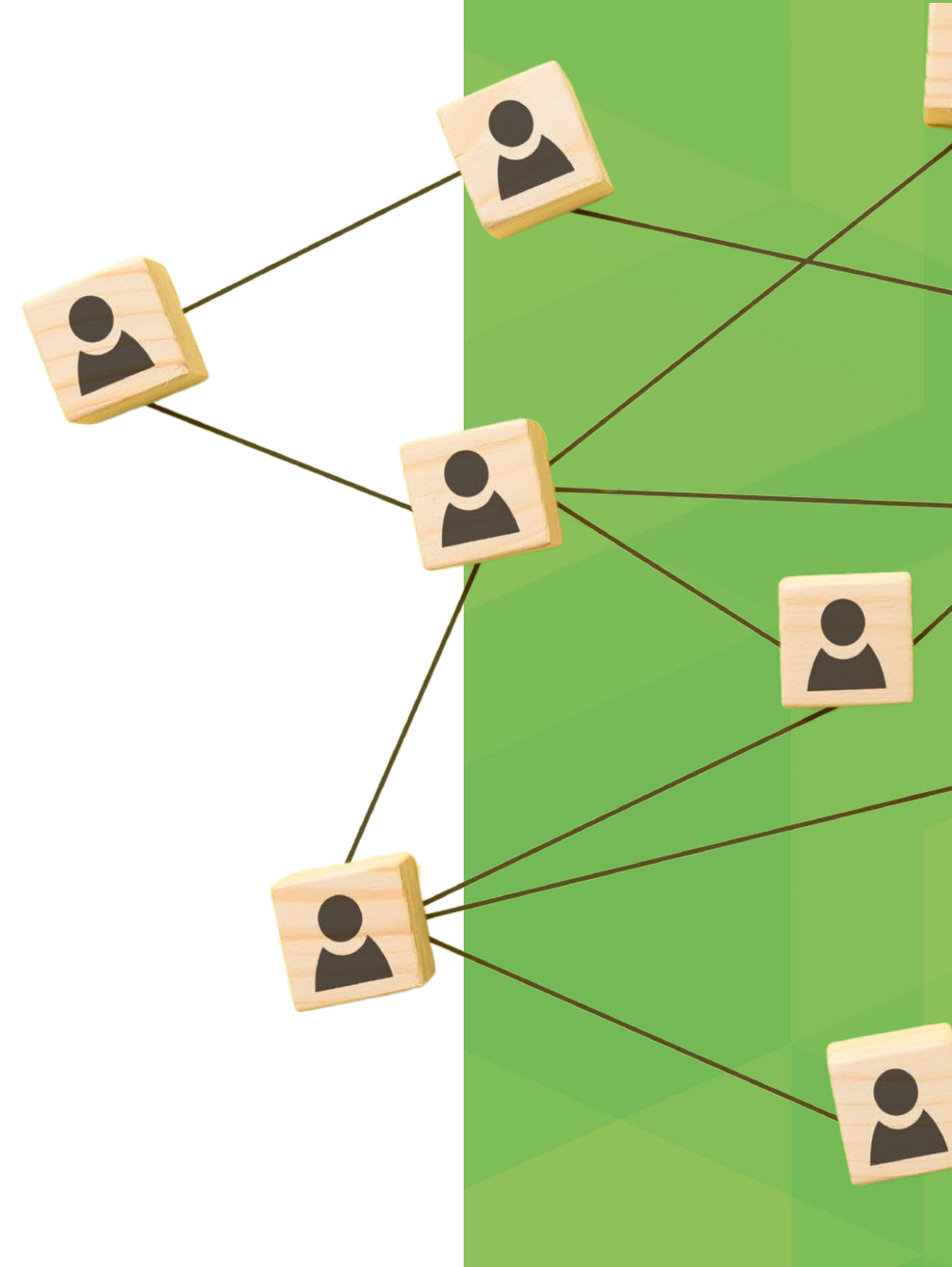
- 146 Direct Service Staff
- 47 Supervisors





OUTREACH AND ENGAGEMENT STRATEGY

- In-person launch event
- Wave-specific virtual kickoffs
- Infographics and flyers
- Ongoing email communication to share updates and reiterate expectations



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INTERNAL INFRASTRUCTURE BUILDING

- xAPI with Cornerstone
- API with Tableau
- Internal reports developed for tracking



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MI CONNECT

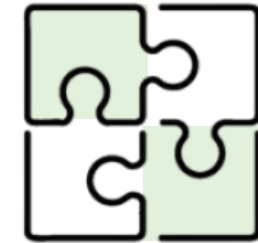
ONGOING SUSTAINABILITY

DIRECT SERVICE STAFF LEARNING JOURNEY

PREREQUISITES

QUARTERLY MI SKILLS CHECK

MI GROUP PRACTICE



PREREQUISITES

USING COACHING TO ADVANCE

COACHING

SUPERVISOR LEARNING JOURNEY

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MI CONNECT

SUCCESSES & LESSONS LEARNED



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OUR SUCCESSES

- The workforce embraced AI.
- The prior MI training requirement and expectation supported the rollout of MI Connect.
- Our intentional engagement of partner agencies from the outset contributed to a successful MI Connect rollout that complemented their existing EBMs.
- We built on existing collaborative relationships with internal stakeholders.



OUR LESSONS LEARNED

- Implementation is a process. Communication needs to be clear and concrete and not overwhelming.
- Cultural change and ongoing adoption of best practice requires buy-in and alignment with all levels of leadership.
- AI tools must be built and tested with diverse populations to truly support the NYC workforce. Ongoing assessment and refinement are needed to ensure continued alignment with the needs of a diverse workforce.



QUESTIONS



Thank you